It was now Nair's turn to feel the heat. Ratan got the support of the communities through favourable press. More workers began accepting the management's proposals. He also indirectly conveyed to the workers the job prospects that their families stood to benefit from if they allowed additional expansion projects in Pune by creating conditions conducive to it. All this threatened to erode Nair's support base and reduce his relevance. Moreover, contrary to the union's claim that the production of cars had come to a standstill, the workers realized that the production, though declining, had not stopped despite the strike. It affected their morale and determination to continue with the agitation.

Faced with growing disenchantment among workers, Nair made a desperate attempt to gain the upper hand in the stand-off. Two days after the management's agreement with the TEU, he with around 3,000 workers, many of them outsiders, went on an indefinite fast within the Shaniwar Wada Fort in the heart of Pune. The move was strategic—to gain public sympathy and corner the management.

All of them wore red bandanas around their forehead with the initials RNP, which stood for 'Rajan Nair Panel'. It, however, sat oddly with the trade union leader's professed selfless concern for the workers of TELCO. Many saw it as a self-serving exercise, which did not go down well with the neutral workers or members of the rival union.

Nair nevertheless wielded considerable clout and a one-day bandh was observed in the Pimpri–Chinchwad region. On the third day of the hunger strike, it was reported that workers had started fainting.

The situation was getting worse. It got the state's political leaders worried too, as the unrest threatened to unsettle the state ruling party's political fortunes. With the ninth general elections scheduled to be held just a month later, Pawar intervened. The logjam was broken and both sides agreed to meet at the chief minister's residence on 27 September. Ratan was to arrive the same day from the US.

Nair's trade union tried to utilize the opportunity to pressurize the management and strong-arm the new chairman. They got Datta Samant, who had brought the entire textile industry in Bombay to a halt for a year some seven years ago, and was a name that many industrialists feared, to lead a march to Bombay House. Nair, on his part, led other rallies and engaged the press. His apparent strategy was to overawe the management before the scheduled meeting. But Ratan remained unflustered and stood his